

necktie.

To go with the mood, the delectable items on the menu come with a sprinkle of cricket: Sangakkara's seafood pasta, Sharma's satay burger, Cairns carbonara, among others.

For the Diary, on a sweltering Colombo afternoon, the place was a pleasant retreat. In the company of cricket's greatest heroes, it was also a chance to soak in the sport's heritage.

Abhishek Saini

Devotion without dividends

To pledge loyalty to a cricket team is akin to signing a contract in invisible ink, binding one's emotions to the contrasting fortunes of 11 strangers.

It is to willingly sacrifice your energy, sleep schedules, and sometimes meals for a service where returns aren't guaranteed. There is no salary, no provident funds, and no pension. Even happiness isn't assured.

Your chartered accountant will tell you it's a bad investment. But who reads offer documents before investing in mutual funds, anyway?

Fandom operates on disproportion. It is a thankless voluntary job because, in the frenzy of liturgy, one is, more often than not, invisible. And nowhere is this drama more operatic than in Indian cricket. Voices get swallowed by roars, and the devotion of that one hypothetical fan — who may have skipped his cousin's wedding to be there — just goes unacknowledged.

Perhaps that's what makes the job noble. You fall in love and do so unconditionally.

But these little stories do not always end in heartbreaks.

Take February 26, India vs. Zimbabwe at the T20 World Cup, for example. Members of Reverse Sweep x North Stand are tearing their throats raw, singing a shantyesque tribute for Abhishek Sharma fielding at long-off. There are others who are simply calling out his name. But wholly concentrated on his assignment, the Indian opener doesn't look back. He is not to be blamed; that's the tunnel vision



Voicing support: The Chepauk crowd 'courts' Tilak Varma during India's T20 World Cup 2026 match against Zimbabwe. SANTADEEP DEY

elite sport demands.

The efforts, however, continue.

At the turn of the over, Tilak Varma jogs into the position. The ritual follows — the songs with slightly altered lyrics, the shoutouts, and the claps. Tilak is unmoved.

But soon, a wind of change sweeps across the venue, this time without Scorpions frontman Klaus Meine's tenor ushering it in. Halfway into Reverse Sweep x North Stand's chorus, Tilak breaks into a jig. And that is enough for the whole of Chepauk to clock in.

For a fan, the smallest gesture had just crossed the quiet line between moment and mythology — fleeting seconds of memory they will guard like buried treasure for an entire lifetime.

Santadeep Dey

The fall and rise in Ahmedabad

The Motera in Ahmedabad was a smaller ground while a statue of a

bull outside lent it character. In its present avatar as the Narendra Modi Stadium, the venue is a massive edifice, accommodating more than a lakh fans.

On the fringes, and beyond the fenced walls, are cramped residential quarters, with people doing their daily chores. In this theatre of the spectacular and the mundane, India suffered a reality-check as South Africa won the Super Eight game by 76 runs on February 22. The verdict left the host staring at must-win games during the rest of the ICC T20 World Cup.

The Men in Blue did that and capped the fine run with a 96-run triumph over New Zealand in the summit clash at Ahmedabad on March 8.

A sea of blue witnessed Sanju Samson's epochal comeback story, and India won the trophy on a frenzied Sunday night.

K.C. Vijaya Kumar